

NT38 Enrichment

†1. A young woman, a university student's testimony to a professor who accused Brigham Young of ordering the Mountain Meadows Massacre and Joseph Smith's description of Paul:

"Part of the baptismal covenant is a commitment to 'stand as a witness of God at all times and in all things, and in all places . . . even unto death.' The construction of this phrase appeals to me. We are to 'stand' as witnesses: not sit, not kneel, not recline: stand! The selection of this word to be a part of this covenant is more than grammatical fortune. Most of the time when we deliver our witness of God and his work, especially to a hostile audience, we will be standing.

"I was in a college Sociology class following my mission. The teacher was engaging. His lectures reached into my heart and mind and I enjoyed almost everything he did. Almost. In spite of repeated claims that he was a member of the church and an active one (he told us he taught Gospel Doctrine in a local ward), he seldom skipped an opportunity to criticize the church. He may have done this from an inflated sense of the need to get his students (who were mostly Latter-day Saints) to think for themselves, or from a sincere belief that the church was too autocratic. At any rate, I learned early in the course that he would challenge my willingness to "stand as a witness" from time to time.

"The first time it happened, the discussion had turned to the Mountain Meadows Massacre. I am not sure now, at a distance of 34 years, how we got from sociology to Iron County but we were there and Dr. Whoever it was directed a searching discussion into the causes of that tragic event. At one point, because of a comment from an interested but uniformed non-member student, the professor observed that to his certain knowledge, the death of the wagon train members at Mountain Meadows had been ordered by Brigham Young himself.

"I was jerked from my cautious interest in the discussion as a non-participant, anxious to get on to other less controversial things, to a position of responsibility. I knew that what I had just heard was not true. I had studied enough church history and read enough of the documents about this event to know that Brigham Young tried desperately to prevent the least inconvenience from coming to the members of the wagon train. I thought about making that very point. I had just returned from two years of standing as a witness. But I was in a class of perhaps one hundred and seventy students (this was a required undergraduate class) and I was surrounded by strangers. I was reluctant to make a display of myself, and besides, my declaration would not matter that much anyway, would it? I sat, wrestling with myself in the silence following this statement, hoping the discussion would turn in another direction.

"And then, exactly in front of me, a young woman stood. Her hands gripped the back of the chair before her. Her voice was tight and she quivered with emotion.

'Dr. Whoever you are, I'm a new member of this church. I was baptized less than a year ago. I've never even heard of the Mountain Meadows Massacre, so I don't know what you're talking about. But I know you are wrong!' And she sat down.

"This was, I believe, the most powerful lesson I learned in college. No teacher ever reached into my heart the way her simple, powerful testimony did. She was willing to stand as a witness when I was not. But I made a promise to myself that day, studying the back of her head, consumed by my own shame. I told myself that I would never sit again when it was time for me to stand. This is a promise I have tried to keep.

"As we study Acts 21-28, we will see again and again Paul standing as a witness. He would have been on his feet in an instant in that class, his eyes blazing, his voice like 'the roaring of a lion.'" (Ted L. Gibbons, New Testament Lesson 38: "[Thou Hast Testified of Me](#)," at [LDSLiving.com](#), Sep. 04, 2015.)

†2. C. Wilfred Griggs: "Many have not understood that Saul joined the Church in addition to gaining a testimony of Christ, and was consequently obedient to church authorities as well as to the Savior; many mistakenly assume that the two allegiances can conflict. These people think that Saul was independent from the church and had sufficient authority from his vision to perform his new duties.

"Instead, we see that after being healed, Saul submitted to baptism (see [Acts 9:18](#)), later went to Tarsus as commanded by "the brethren" (see [Acts 9:30](#)), went to Antioch under the direction of Barnabas (see [Acts 11:26](#)), and went on his missionary journey after being set apart and commissioned by the church authorities. ("[Paul: The Long Road From Damascus](#)," *Ensign*, September 1975)

†3. Elder Bruce R. McConkie: "In his persecuted and straitened state, Paul needed comfort and assurance from on high. How shall such be given him? The Lord could have sent an angel; he could have spoken by the power of the Holy Spirit to the spirit within Paul; or he could have opened the heavens and let him see again the wonders of eternity. But this time—thanks to his valiant service, his unwearying devotion, his willingness to suffer even unto death in the Cause of Christ—this time Paul was blessed with the personal ministrations of the Lord of heaven himself. Jesus stood at his side. Without question much was said and much transpired, of which there has been preserved to us only the promise that the Lord's special apostle would yet bear witness of the Master in Rome" (*Doctrinal New Testament Commentary*, 3 vols. [1965–1973], 2:191).

†4. Elder Russell M. Nelson on a clear conscience (See Acts 23:1 and Acts 24:16.): "One day each of us will give an account to the Lord. This awareness was evident in a serious conversation I had years ago with a dear friend facing the end of his mortal life. I asked him

if he was ready to die. I'll never forget his answer. With courage and conviction, he said, 'My life is ready for inspection.'

"When the Prophet Joseph Smith faced death, he said, 'I am going like a lamb to the slaughter; but I am calm as a summer's morning; I have a conscience void of offense towards God, and towards all men' [D&C 135:4].

"Now is the time to prepare for your own ultimate interview. You might ask yourself: 'Do I pay tithing with a willing heart? Do I obey the Word of Wisdom? Is my language free from obscenities and swearing? Am I morally righteous? Am I truly grateful for the Atonement that makes my resurrection a reality and eternal life a possibility? Do I honor temple covenants that seal loved ones to me forever?'" (["Personal Priesthood Responsibility,"](#) *Ensign* or *Liahona*, Nov. 2003, 44–45).

†5. **Elder M. Russell Ballard on Felix who said “when I have a convenient season, I will call for thee.” (Acts 24:25):** “Sometimes we are tempted to let our lives be governed more by convenience than by covenant. It is not always convenient to live gospel standards and stand up for truth and testify of the Restoration. It usually is not convenient to share the gospel with others. It isn't always convenient to respond to a calling in the Church, especially one that stretches our abilities. Opportunities to serve others in meaningful ways, as we have covenanted to do, rarely come at convenient times. But there is no spiritual power in living by convenience. The power comes as we keep our covenants” (["Like a Flame Unquenchable,"](#) *Ensign*, May 1999, 86).

†6. **Elder L. Tom Perry:** “The growing visibility and reputation of the Church presents some remarkable opportunities to us as its members. We can help “disabuse the public mind” and correct misinformation when we are portrayed as something we are not. More important, though, we can share who we are.

“There are a number of things that we can do—that you can do—to advance an understanding of the Church. If we do it with the same spirit and if we conduct ourselves in the same way we do when we host a temple open house, our friends and our neighbors will come to understand us better. Their suspicions will evaporate, negative stereotypes will disappear, and they will begin to understand the Church as it really is.

“Let me suggest a few ideas of what we can do.

“First, we must be bold in our declaration of Jesus Christ. We want others to know that we believe He is the central figure in all human history. His life and teachings are the heart of the Bible and the other books we consider to be holy scripture. The Old Testament sets the stage for Christ's mortal ministry. The New Testament describes His mortal ministry. The Book of Mormon gives us a second witness of His mortal ministry... Only through Jesus Christ is salvation possible. This is why we believe He is the central figure in all human history. Our eternal destiny is always in His hands. It is a

glorious thing to believe in Him and accept Him as our Savior, our Lord, and our Master...

“Second, be righteous examples to others. After our declaration of our beliefs, we must follow the counsel given to us in [1 Timothy 4:12](#): “But be thou an example of the believers, in word, in conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity.” ...

“Next, speak up about the Church. In the course of our everyday lives, we are blessed with many opportunities to share our beliefs with others. When our professional and personal associates inquire about our religious beliefs, they are inviting us to share who we are and what we believe. They may or may not be interested in the Church, but they are interested in getting to know us at a deeper level.

“My recommendation to you is to accept their invitations. Your associates are not inviting you to teach, preach, expound, or exhort. Engage them in a two-way conversation—share something about your religious beliefs but also ask them about their beliefs. Gauge the level of interest by the questions they ask. If they are asking a lot of questions, focus the conversation on answering those questions. Always remember that it is better for them to ask than for you to tell.” (["Perfect Love Casteth Out Fear,"](#) Conference address, October 2011.)

†7. **Ted L. Gibbons:** “Paul not only stood as a witness, but he did it in the face of personal hazard and continuing danger. He said of himself,

“Of the Jews five times received I forty stripes save one. Thrice was I beaten with rods, once was I stoned, thrice I suffered shipwreck, a night and a day I have been in the deep; In journeyings often, in perils of waters, in perils of robbers, in perils by mine own countrymen, in perils by the heathen, in perils in the city, in perils in the wilderness, in perils in the sea, in perils among false brethren; In weariness and painfulness, in watchings often, in hunger and thirst, in fastings often, in cold and nakedness. Beside those things that are without, that which cometh upon me daily, the care of all the churches” (2 Cor. 11: 24-28).

Recommended Reading:

1. Ted L. Gibbons, New Testament Lesson 38: [“Thou Hast Testified of Me,”](#) at LDSLiving.com, Sep. 04, 2015. Brother Gibbons tells a great story about a new member, a young woman, a university student who bore her testimony to provocative professor who accused President Brigham Young of ordering the Mountain Meadows Massacre.

2. Nancy Jensen, [New Testament Lesson #38 “Thou Hast Testified of Me,”](#) at LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, September 18, 2011.

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